

**Book Critique:
Thematic
Analysis by
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“We imagine qualitative analysis as an adventure, and one that is typically messy and organic, complex and contested—’more messy, more convoluted and more surprising than we thought it would be’”



Section I: Venturing Forth! Doing Reflexive Thematic Analysis



Familiarization with
your data



Doing the coding



Development of
themes from coded
data



Guides the process
of reported findings

Section I Takeaways



Reflexive TA emphasizes the subjective nature of research, highlighting the importance of researcher reflexivity throughout the analysis



Familiarization with the dataset is essential; it involves active, analytical reading and making initial notes



Coding can be inductive (data-driven) or deductive (theory-driven), and researchers should be comfortable with its subjective nature



Researchers should ensure that their report reflects their reflexivity and analytic process, enhancing transparency

Section II: Going Deeper for Tip-Top Reflexive TA: Theory, Interpretation, & Quality Matters

- Discusses the theoretical underpinnings of reflexive TA and emphasizes the relationship between qualitative research and theory
- Describes various interpretative approaches from descriptive to critical analysis
- Provides strategies for ensuring interpretations are defensible and contextualized
- Compares reflexive TA with other TA approaches
- Offers guidelines for maintaining quality in reflexive TA, including reflexive journaling and developing a qualitative sensibility

Section II Takeaways



Understanding ontology and epistemology is essential



Reflexivity and ethical considerations are crucial to ensure interpretations are contextualized and minimize misrepresentation



Reflexive TA differs from other TA approaches in its emphasis on researcher subjectivity and flexibility



Ensuring quality in TA requires reflexivity, a clear analytic trail, and a strong connection to qualitative principles

That 15-point Checklist

1. Transcription
2. Each data item has been given repeated and thorough attention in the coding process
3. The coding process has been thorough
4. All relevant extracts for each theme have been collated
5. Themes have been checked against coded and original data
6. Themes are internally consistent and coherent
7. Data have been analyzed
8. Analysis and data match each other
9. Analysis tells a convincing and well-organized story
9. An appropriate balance between analytic narrative and data extracts is provided
9. Process is not rushed, and adequate time has been spent with the data
9. The specific approach to TA, and the particulars of the approach are clearly explained
9. There is a good fit between what is claimed, and what was done
9. The language and concepts used in the report are consistent with the epistemological framework
9. The researcher is positioned as *active* in the research



Strengths & Limitations

Strengths

- Comprehensive and Practical Approach
- Emphasis on Reflexivity
- Rich Theoretical Context
- Clear Illustrations and Examples
- Pedagogical Tools and Companion Resources

Limitations

- Focused on Reflexive TA Only
- Theoretical Depth May Overwhelm Beginners
- Subjectivity and Flexibility Emphasis
- Potential Bias Towards Authors' Perspective
- Limited Application to Quantitative- and Mixed Methods-Oriented Researchers

Why This Book?



Plan to use this method of coding and analysis in my research



The nature of YPAR means that I will always be somewhat of an outsider and the explicit focus on reflection and the cyclical process of coding I think will help give me additional perspectives and enhance the rigor of my project



The Saldaña text from class also suggests this method of coding when working with people's lived experiences and perspectives, which is my primary data source



References

- Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2022). *Thematic analysis: A practical guide*. SAGE.
- Saldaña, J. (2021b). *Coding manual for qualitative researchers* (4th ed.). Sage Publications Ltd.